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ТЕХНОЛОГИЯ • ИСКУССТВЕННЫЙ ИНТЕЛЛЕКТ

Подписаться

Гиганты искусственного интеллекта раздают тонны бесплатных вычислительных мощностей, чтобы получить долю от стартапов

Ожесточенная битва за бизнес-пользователей разгорается по мере того, как компании, занимающиеся искусственным интеллектом, ищут долгосрочные источники дохода

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Инвесторы общаются с основателями стартапов на демонстрационном дне Y Combinator в Сан-Франциско в марте. ПОППИ ЛИНЧ ДЛЯ WSJ

Ханс Ибарра, основатель стартапа по разработке голосового ИИ, оказался в выигрышной ситуации: ведущие компании в области искусственного интеллекта, такие как OpenAI, Anthropic и другие, отчаянно стремящиеся заполучить его бизнес, предлагают все более выгодные условия.

По всей Кремниевой долине основатели стартапов, такие как Ибарра, пользуются волной скидок на вычислительные мощности и получают конкурирующие предложения от разработчиков ИИ-моделей, стремящихся заполучить новых корпоративных клиентов. Cursor, компания, занимающаяся разработкой искусственного интеллекта, которую купила SpaceX Илона Маска, предлагала 75-процентную скидку до 5 июля.

Предложения от растущих армий продавцов ИИ в таких компаниях, как OpenAI и Anthropic, настолько заманчивы, что некоторые основатели стартапов на ранних стадиях говорят, что им не придется привлекать финансирование так скоро, как они рассчитывали, а другие смогли переманить клиентов у компаний, работающих в сфере ИИ. По словам основателей, стартапы получали предложения, которые в некоторых случаях включали кредиты на сумму более 3 миллионов долларов от нескольких компаний на облачные вычисления и токены — основные единицы измерения и оплаты за использование ИИ. По данным PitchBook, это средний размер посевного раунда в США.

GOOGL 1,17 %**рост; зеленый треугольник, направленный вверх ▲**

предоставляет некоторым стартапам облачные кредиты на сумму до 500 000 долларов и ранний доступ к моделям Gemini. По словам представителя Google, компания также иногда предоставляет особый доступ инженерам DeepMind. Microsoft и Amazon Web Services также предлагают стартапам особые привилегии.

The pitched battle for business users comes as AI companies seek lasting streams of revenue. They hope that by winning startups as customers early in the life of new companies, their tools will become integral to the venture's growth over time.

OpenAI and Anthropic are offering a string of promotions and one-time bonuses, even as both companies face enormous pressure to improve their margins ahead of expected initial public offerings. They also face competition from increasingly powerful “open weight,” or free models, as well as cheaper ones, many of which were developed in China.

The token deals available to founders “directly correlate to the scale you can grow your product,” said Ibarra, co-founder of Dialogus. “If you’re not getting this deal, you will need to raise money to buy those.”

Anthropic’s revenue skyrocketed late last year as millions of new users tapped their Claude Code and Cowork software to autonomously complete a range of tasks. Claude’s viral popularity helped launch the “agentic” AI era, in which top AI companies are increasingly focused on building tools that customers can use to complete long-running knowledge-work tasks, such as coding and deep research.

For months, OpenAI struggled to match the strength of Anthropic’s coding-focused models and products, giving its younger rival the advantage in the lucrative enterprise market. Companies initially nudged employees to use AI more in their work, but soon some saw the bills as prohibitively high.

OpenAI’s fortunes began to change after the March release of a new model, called GPT-5.4, that matched many of Anthropic’s capabilities. The company has since deployed its salespeople to sell its Codex tool, which is powered by its GPT model, to startups across Silicon Valley, oftentimes offering volume discounts and other sweeteners to win new customers.

Semianalysis, an AI-infrastructure data and consulting firm, recently published research showing how heavily the companies are subsidizing power users.

Subscribers to Anthropic’s Claude Max plan, which costs \$200 a month, are able to burn tokens worth \$8,000 in their usage-based plans administered through an application programming interface, or API, which allows them to integrate Anthropic’s technology into their products. Maximum use of OpenAI’s ChatGPT Pro 20x plan, which also costs \$200 a month, can burn tokens worth \$14,000.

In their quest to secure new business customers, Anthropic and OpenAI have zeroed in on startups participating in Y Combinator, the Silicon Valley institution that launched Airbnb and Stripe. In May, Sam Altman announced that OpenAI would give \$2 million in token credits to every startup participating in the accelerator program in exchange for equity in those companies.



Y Combinator runs four cohorts a year. POPPY LYNCH FOR WSJ

Around the same time, Anthropic began offering Y Combinator startups \$500,000 in free credits, a sharp increase from the \$30,000 it previously offered, an Anthropic spokeswoman said. Anthropic's offer doesn't require startups to give up equity.

Soon afterward, in recent weeks, OpenAI adjusted its deal, offering startups \$500,000 in free credits—no equity required—with an optional additional \$1.5 million in credits in exchange for equity, according to people familiar with the matter.

The back-and-forth reflects the intense battle the companies are in to sway young startups that could become large customers in the future. Model providers hope that by offering these companies discounts, they can lock them into their ecosystem.

At an event hosted to kick off the summer season of Y Combinator's program, representatives from OpenAI and Anthropic, among others, met with startup founders and offered advice about making the most of their token usage, including by embracing loop engineering, or teaching AI agents to repeat a task until they have achieved their assigned goal.

Touchmark, an AI startup that was accepted by Y Combinator in May, was immediately granted \$1 million in token credits from OpenAI and Anthropic before the accelerator even kicked off its summer session.

For Ilia Bolgov, co-founder of Touchmark, the credits meant "quite a lot of time to go all-in on tokenmaxxing," a term for using as many tokens as

possible, he said. “It’s hard to imagine productivity now without these deals.”

The credits represent a massive potential investment on behalf of the model providers. Y Combinator runs four cohorts a year, with recent cohorts enrolling about 200 companies each, meaning OpenAI and Anthropic could offer up to \$800 million in combined AI credits in the next year.

“The world of AI is being powered by OpenAI and Anthropic because they are giving startups the money to pay for it,” said Christopher Acker, co-founder of SuperPenguin, a firm that helps companies track their AI spending.

“If I’m choosing between a really cheap Chinese model that I actually have to pay for, and a very expensive Anthropic model that I don’t have to pay for, I’m going to pick the Anthropic model,” Acker said. “I’m always going to pick the one for which I have free credits.”

Энджел Ау-Йенг — репортер The Wall Street Journal, освещающая вопросы финансов и технологий в Сан-Франциско. Она пишет о бизнес-лидерах, стартапах и культуре Кремниевой долины. Она получила несколько национальных наград за свою работу, в том числе за...



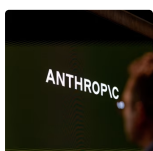
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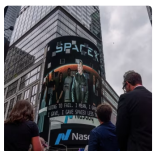
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